

Moonsea Rising - 20240629

The Ironride's Maiden Voyage

While Lennox is off getting his tattoos, Lirael talks to Hermiphony and Clementh, who introduces her the engineer, Glimmerknock Steamwhistle, asking about why the Ironride is such a target for bandits. He explains that specially treated and ensorcelled gems power the Ironride without depletion, potentially for millenia. While expensive to produce, and highly-valuable over the lifetime of the train, they will cost much less over the years. There are a dozen in the engine, and one smaller one in each trailing car. Lirael asks what happens if the cars' gems are interfered with. Glimmerknock tells her the cars drag would start to accumulate and could potentially still the train itself.

Taevyn tags along with Lennox to the tattoo parlor, pumping the man for dating advice for his imagined courtship of Kia Kilaudra. Harken has Lirael stow his skull on the train so he can subtly explore the train and see how it works. Beitris, with the Baroness' help, pens an apology letter to Doran Ma. She also studies the game book more, finding that while it's dedicated towards building the Empire in the best possible way, all of the actions seem to be centered around the founding, such that all actions taken then determine the final outcome of the game. It seems heavily biased in favor of their original reality, though she, like Lirael, doesn't think this version is so bad. She scours the rulebook, looking for hints about optimizing outcomes in the real world, while theorizing that the games are representative of a real power struggle among powerful individuals.

She and Taevyn are both worried about possibly facing Nikolai and Uriah. Beitris takes a hard line that these aren't people they know, just temporal doppelgängers of people they left behind. She counsels striking if need be.

As the party joins Harken on the Ironride, he fills them in on the layout of the train, containing:

- locomotive
- luggage car
- 2x passenger cars
- luxury berths
- dining car
- kitchen car
- caboose

He tells them that the cars have a pull-cord for distress signalling to the engine, as well as a fully-staffed orcish crew, in the event of non-emergency messaging.

As the party positions themselves throughout the train (Lirael in the locomotive, Lennox in luggage, Beitris in the luxury car looking for plants, Harken back in dining, and Taevyn with his cross-bow in the caboose), the Ironride prepares to depart. Taevyn eyes the ladders to the roof with interest, a far-away look in his eyes.

They settle down for the six hour trip to Thar and the Ironride sets out. The first couple of hours are uneventful, but late in the second hour, Lirael's ears pick up the sound of horses along the track to the south. Looking out of the engine, she sees a number of horsemen with red face paint and bows approaching. Lennox also notices, as they nock arrows and aim towards him.

Lennox bolts to his feet, roaring a challenge, as they begin loosing arrows. They rain down around the big man as he ponders returning the attack. Back in the lap of luxury, Beitris continues sipping a sparkling orcish beverage, listening to the drummer in the corner, completely missing the man's yell.

Lennox drops flat against the train roof, until someone comes in range of him. Another archer fires, hitting him in the thigh, though the angle makes doing worse damage difficult. In the kitchen, Harken is trying to telekinectically filch small morsels he cannot enjoy. Lennox continues taking fire, the train car helping him significantly, though not protecting him completely. From the engine Lirael slings a ray of frost at the lead rider, striking him, and quickly taking cover in the engine again.

As the riders start to lose ground to the train, the archers continue to fire at Lennox, but the train's speed works to his advantage here. Glancing briefly to her left, Beitris notices a group of five horsemen clearly firing arrows at someone further up the train. She steps out onto the joiner platform between the cars firing her crossbow and ducking around the corner. Lennox reconsiders axe usage, and swings down into the luggage car, grabbing his bow and getting ready to return fire. The bowmen fire at Beitris, their arrows clattering off the corner of the train car.

Harken's incorporeal ears twitch, as he notices the frightened screams of passengers further up the train. He moves forward, trying to locate the source of the danger. A couple of the archers manages to tag Beitris with arrows, as the Ironride rolls one.

In the caboose, Taevyn scans the western horizon, and manages to catch sight of the bowmen to his southeast. Taevyn grabs the roof, flipping up on top of the train and sprints towards the engine, rolling off his leap between the cars, and covering two cars in a matter of seconds. Lirael fires another ray of frost, and begins awkwardly moving back along the train as the horsemen continue lagging.

The horsemen, now alongside Beitris, fire a series of arrows at her, hitting her again. Moving into the carriage, she ducks down behind the walls. Invoking Lathander, she heals some of her wounds. Bow in hand, Lennox runs back out of the luggage car, heaving himself up onto the roof, and continuing towards the caboose. He immediately takes arrow fire, another one striking him.

Harken focuses, gesturing at the path. Limestone spikes erupt under the horsemen. With horrible screams, several of the horse pitch directly in the spikes, writhing and kicking, trapping their riders, and bleeding from scores of lacerations. Only two of the riders manage to avoid the horror-show Harken has summoned. One of them manages to hit Lennox with another arrow, as Taevyn continues to race along the train top. Rolling through one of his jumps, he catches a glimpse of a figure climbing onto the roof of the caboose. Spinning, he fires his crossbow at the unknown figure. A bolt, rimed with frost magic, strikes the newcomer, who tumbles off the roof and out of sight. Taevyn shouts about attackers from the south.

At the far end, Lirael hears none of that. Swaying with the train, she makes her way back towards the first passenger car. The two remaining horsemen fire their bows on Taevyn as the motion of the Ironride brings him closer. Beitris looks at the lagging horsemen, as they fall further behind. Suspicious as ever, she tries to signal Lirael that there might well be enemies on the train. As she's doing that, a robed passenger in carriage's hood slips down, and Beitris immediately recognizes Nikolai Steele. The man is doing a good job of feigning fear, and quickly pulls his hood back into place. Looking back at Lirael, she points directly at Nikolai Steele. Shouldering her crossbow, she fires a bolt at him, missing.

Lennox races down the roof, leaping to the second passenger car, and loosing a bowshot that hits the lead rider square in the chest. The man rocks in his saddle, but stays upright. Harken, hearing Taevyn's warning, turns invisible and heads towards the back of the train. A couple more arrows strike Taevyn. At the back, the robed female Taevyn shot pulls herself back onto the roof. She slings an acid arrow at Taevyn, striking him and covering him in corrosive goop. Taevyn returns fire with his crossbow, hitting her twice. He backs up along the train.

Lirael continues forward, slinging a ray of frost at Nikolai, but the motion of the train knocks her askew. He turns to rush Beitris, who shifts her crossbow out of the way, and motions him to come on, watching him carefully for any kind of reaction. At the last second, instead of running her through, he slaps the crossbow out of her hands with his sword, scowling in confusion.

As the horsemen begin to fall out of range, the only target they can see is Taevyn, and two more arrows hit him.

In the second passenger car, Beitris attempts to throw her arms around Nikolai and kiss him. He is intensely confused, especially as she calls him by name. She attempts to use their code phrase, but he doesn't recognize it, and is looking around for other hostiles, assuming this is a distraction. He tells her, "you seem to have me at a disadvantage; you know me, but I don't know you."

Lennox, completely unaware of what's happening below him, continues advancing to Taevyn's position, firing on the caster who attacked him. He fires again, striking her heavily with an arrow.

Harken climbs up on a table and pokes his head through the roof. He casts a phantasmal killer at the woman, who is wracked with the illusory damage. The horsemen fire at Taevyn, hitting him with one arrow, and causing his shark-tooth tattoo to flare up shattering the second shot. Taevyn's eye's flash briefly black as he glares at the rider.

The mage fires a lightning bolt at Taevyn, who dances aside, chuckling. He grabs a healing potion from his belt, quaffing it in a gulp, and firing the crossbow at the mage. The bolt catches her in the throat, frost ringing the wound as she tumbles limply off the back of the train. His second shot hits the man who shot him, grievously wounding him. Lirael continues moving towards Beitris and Nikolai, stopping between the cars and hiding around the corner.

Nikolai raises his sword to attempt to knock Beitris out. Frowning, she moves to one side, and his successive strikes are even less successful. She says, "if you wanted to dance, Nikolai, you could have just asked me." He continues to be confused and upset, potentially unaware of how badly his raid is going. He points out that he doesn't know her, and she's in league with the orcs of the Ironride. She tells him, as a priest of Lathander, she can force herself to only speak the truth. He looks at her, considers, and says "do it."

She casts a zone of truth, and tells him she must speak truth. He asks her if she's in league with Ironclaw, and she admits that she'd met him just recently. He asks if she's protecting the Ironride, and she likewise admits it's true. He asks how she knows who he is, and she tells him, "in another timeline, you and I had a very different relationship." He is very confused.

Running out of foes, Lennox moves to the gap between the luxury and dining cars, and drops down to train level. He continues forward, calling to the others for status. Glancing down, Lirael notices someone down below, trying to decouple the link between the passenger cars.

Harken continues to move to the back of the train, entering the kitchen car. He immediately notices all three orcish cooks lie dead on the ground, and a woman in black with red face paint stands over them. She appears to be putting something into one of the ovens. He reaches out, and black energy crackles around her, rippling into his invisible plasim. She whirls around, looking for her attacker. Taevyn continues to the back of the train, dropping down between the cars, and tumbling into the kitchen. He pops up with rapier drawn.

Lirael spreads her hands, concentrating, and pets swarm out of the air, whirling and biting him. Channeling the latent energy from the spell into her spear, she flings it at the man, hitting him. He grunts at the pain, but remains focused on his task.

Meanwhile, in the kitchen, the black-clad woman decides Taevyn is her assailant. Quickly envenoming her weapon, she stabs him with it.

Nikolai asks Beitris, "what do you mean a different timeline? Are you from the future?" She tells him she's from an alternate time when there was a Moonsea Empire, and Nikolai was a Baron. He is incredulous, tells her she's mad. She asks him why he's so against the train. He believes it's an evil orc plot, and a magical disaster waiting to happen. The lightning and fire gems could destroy massive areas when, not if, control over them is lost. As he turns to leave, she raises one hand and touches his face. He looks towards Lirael and the man working the coupling, but turns back.

Lennox comes up behind Beitris and sees this tender moment. Having his bow in his hand, he fires an arrow, hitting Nikolai in the shoulder. Cursing, the man pushes Beitris away from him, raising his sword again.

Harken summons the phantasmal killer in the kitchen again, harrying the woman as she struggles with Taevyn. She flinches, but keeps her eyes on the younger man. Taevyn slashes with his rapier, striking her with a flourish that opens a long wound. He follows up attempting to disarm her, but she keeps her grip.

Back with the whipman working the coupling, Lirael focuses, and her form morphs and swells into a massive gorilla. Ripping and tearing at the man, she attempts to fling them both from the train, though he manages to hang on out of pure shock.